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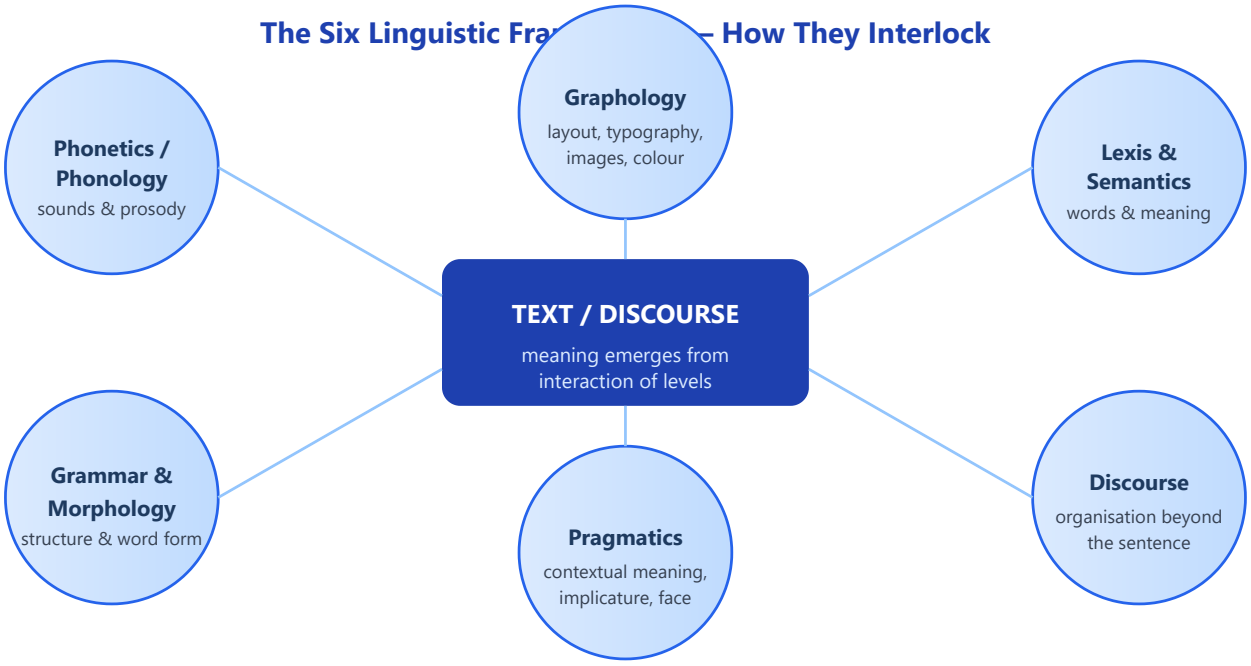
1.1 Methods of Language Analysis

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 1: Language, the Individual and Society — Section 3.1.2

The **six linguistic frameworks** (also called **levels of analysis**) are the toolkit AQA expects you to apply to any text. They are: **phonetics, phonology & prosodics**; **graphology**; **lexis & semantics**; **grammar & morphology**; **pragmatics**; **discourse**. Top-band answers integrate levels rather than listing features at each level in isolation.



1.1.1 Phonetics, Phonology and Prosodics

Phonetics is the study of how speech sounds are physically produced (articulated) and perceived. **Phonology** is the study of how sounds function within the system of a particular language — which sound contrasts carry meaning. **Prosodics** concerns the suprasegmental features of speech: stress, intonation, tempo, rhythm, pause and volume.

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The smallest unit phonology works with is the **phoneme** — a sound that distinguishes meaning. English has around 44 phonemes (numbers vary by dialect). A **minimal pair** is two words differing by only one phoneme, proving that the two sounds are distinct units: *pit* /pɪt/ vs *bit* /bɪt/. Only the initial consonant differs, yet the meanings are different.

Consonant classification

Consonants are classified by three features:

1. **Place of articulation** — where in the mouth the airflow is obstructed (e.g. *bilabial* both lips, *alveolar* tongue against the alveolar ridge, *velar* back of tongue against the soft palate).
2. **Manner of articulation** — how the airflow is obstructed (*plosive/stop*, *fricative*, *affricate*, *nasal*, *approximant*, *lateral*).
3. **Voicing** — whether the vocal folds vibrate (*voiced*) or not (*voiceless*).

Sound	IPA	Example	Classification
p	/p/	pit	Voiceless bilabial plosive
b	/b/	bit	Voiced bilabial plosive
f	/f/	fan	Voiceless labiodental fricative
v	/v/	van	Voiced labiodental fricative
sh	/ʃ/	ship	Voiceless post-alveolar fricative
ch	/tʃ/	chip	Voiceless post-alveolar affricate
m	/m/	man	Voiced bilabial nasal
ng	/ŋ/	sing	Voiced velar nasal

Vowels

Vowels are made without obstruction of airflow and are classified by tongue height (high/close vs low/open), tongue position (front vs back), and lip rounding. English has **monophthongs** (single vowel sounds: /ɪ/ in *bit*) and **diphthongs** (two vowel qualities glided together: /aɪ/ in *time*).

Regional variation is often concentrated in vowels — the *bath/trap* split distinguishes Northern and Southern British English.

Prosodic features you should recognise

Feature	Definition	Why it matters
Stress	Emphasis placed on a syllable or word	Changes word class (*RE*cord vs re*CORD*) and focuses meaning within a sentence.
Intonation	Pitch pattern across an utterance	Rising intonation typically marks questions or checks; falling intonation signals completion or authority.
Tempo	Speed of delivery	Fast speech can signal excitement or nervousness; slow speech can convey gravity, hesitation or emphasis.
Volume	Loudness	Shouting vs whispering encodes emotion and power relations.
Pause	Silence within speech (micro *(.)* or timed *(2.0)*)	Marks planning time, face-saving, turn-giving or dramatic effect.
Rhythm	Temporal patterning of stressed/unstressed syllables	English is a stress-timed language — triadic rhythm ("blood, sweat, tears") is rhetorically powerful.

Exam Tip: You are not expected to be a trained phonetician. What examiners want is that you can identify and comment on the *effect* of sound features — alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia, sibilance, plosiveness — and of prosodic choices in transcripts (stress, intonation, pauses). Always link the feature to meaning or audience effect.

1.1.2 Graphology

Graphology is the visual appearance and organisation of a written text. It includes typography, font choice, colour, layout, spacing, images, punctuation as visual feature, and the relationship between text and non-textual elements on the page or screen.

Historically, graphology was sometimes dismissed as secondary to "real" linguistic analysis. At A-level, you must treat graphological choices as meaningful. A tabloid front page, a perfume advert, a Government leaflet and a personal text message all rely heavily on graphology to position the reader.

Key graphological features

- **Typography** — font family (serif vs sans-serif), weight (bold), style (italic), size, case.
- **Colour** — foreground/background contrast, brand colours, symbolic associations (red = urgency/passion, blue = trust/calm).
- **Layout** — columns, alignment, hierarchy (headlines, subheads, body), use of white space.
- **Images** — photographs, illustrations, icons; relationship to surrounding text (anchoring, relay).
- **Visual punctuation** — bullet points, dashes, exclamation marks used decoratively.
- **Orthographic play** — deliberate mis-spelling for effect (e.g. *Krispy Kreme*), use of emoji, capitals as shouting in digital writing.

Applied Example: A news website uses a large bold serif headline in black, a single colour photograph, and a short Anglo-Saxon, monosyllabic strap-line. The serif font connotes authority and tradition; the black-on-white contrast signals seriousness; the photograph anchors meaning emotionally. Graphology works *with* lexis and syntax to construct a particular register and position the reader as a thoughtful citizen rather than an entertainment-seeker.

1.1.3 Lexis and Semantics

Lexis refers to the vocabulary of a language — the set of words available to speakers.
Semantics is the study of meaning conveyed by lexis and by larger linguistic units.

Lexical classifications

Classification	Details	Example / Effect
Word class	Noun, verb, adjective, adverb, pronoun, preposition, conjunction, determiner, interjection	Distribution of word classes indicates register — heavy nouns + adjectives = descriptive; heavy verbs + adverbs = dynamic narrative.
Etymological origin	Anglo-Saxon (Germanic), Latinate, Greek, French-Norman, borrowings	Anglo-Saxon "home", "dog", "work" feels direct and everyday; Latinate "residence", "canine", "occupation" feels formal, elevated.
Register	Formal, informal, colloquial, slang, taboo, archaic, technical/jargon	A text\'s register positions the reader as insider or outsider of a social group.
Frequency	High-frequency (everyday) vs low-frequency (specialist / literary)	Low-frequency lexis reduces accessibility but can signal prestige or expertise.
Field	Topic or domain (sport, medicine, finance, warfare, religion)	A semantic field frames the subject ideologically — describing a political debate in the semantic field of warfare ("attack", "defend") is not neutral.

Semantic relations

- **Synonyms** — similar meanings (*brave*, *courageous*, *valiant*). Near-synonyms differ in register or connotation.
- **Antonyms** — opposite meanings. *Gradable* (hot/cold), *complementary* (alive/dead), *relational* (buy/sell).
- **Hyponymy** — hierarchical relationships. *Rose* is a hyponym of *flower*; *flower* is the hypernym.
- **Meronymy** — part-whole relationships. *Wheel* is a meronym of *car*.
- **Polysemy** — one word, multiple related meanings (*foot* of a mountain / of a person).

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- **Homonymy** — one form, unrelated meanings: *bank* (river) / *bank* (financial).

Denotation vs Connotation

Denotation is the dictionary definition. **Connotation** is the bundle of associations a word carries — often cultural, emotional or ideological. Writers exploit connotation: describing a politician as "*stubborn*" rather than "*determined*" signals different evaluation even if denotationally similar.

Figurative language — key tropes

- **Metaphor** — implicit comparison: *time is a thief*.
- **Simile** — explicit comparison using *like* or *as*: *quick as a flash*.
- **Personification** — giving human attributes to non-human: *the wind howled*.
- **Metonymy** — using one thing to stand for a related thing: *the Crown* for the monarchy.
- **Synecdoche** — part for whole or whole for part: *all hands on deck*.
- **Hyperbole** — exaggeration: *I\'ve told you a thousand times*.
- **Understatement / litotes** — deliberate downplay: *not bad* (= very good).
- **Euphemism** — softened substitute: *passed away* for *died*.
- **Dysphemism** — deliberately harsh substitute for polite form.

> **Exam Tip:** Avoid feature-spotting. "The writer uses a metaphor" is AO1 at its weakest. "The metaphor *time is a thief* constructs time as an antagonist who takes from us, framing ageing in a semantic field of theft and loss" links feature to meaning — this is what AO1 and AO3 together reward.

1.1.4 Grammar and Morphology

> **Grammar** is the system of rules describing how words combine into phrases, clauses and sentences. **Morphology** is the study of word formation — how morphemes combine to build words.

Morphemes

A **morpheme** is the smallest unit of meaning. Morphemes are classed as:

- **Free morphemes** — stand alone: *cat, run, happy*.
- **Bound morphemes** — must attach: *-s, -ed, un-, re-, -able, -ness*.
- **Inflectional morphemes** — mark grammatical information without changing word class (*cats, walked, taller*).
- **Derivational morphemes** — create new words, often changing class (*happy → happiness*; *teach → teacher*).

Example breakdown: `un-forget-able` = *un-* (bound, negating) + *forget* (free) + *-able* (bound, converting to adjective) — three morphemes.

Word classes

Class	Function	Examples
Noun	Names people, places, things, ideas. Counts as common/proper, concrete/abstract, count/mass.	*tree, London, freedom, water*
Verb	Describes action, process or state. Main / auxiliary (be, have, do) / modal (can, must, should).	*run, is, have, should*
Adjective	Modifies nouns. Can be gradable (comparative/superlative).	*small, smaller, smallest*
Adverb	Modifies verbs, adjectives or other adverbs. Express manner, time, place, degree, frequency.	*quickly, yesterday, very, often*
Pronoun	Replaces noun phrases. Personal / possessive / reflexive / demonstrative / relative / interrogative.	*I, mine, myself, this, who*
Preposition	Relates a noun phrase to another element (time, place, manner).	*in, on, after, despite*

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Conjunction	Joins words, phrases, clauses. Coordinating (and, but, or) / subordinating (although, because, when).	*and, although*
Determiner	Specifies a noun phrase. Articles (a, the), demonstratives, possessives, quantifiers, numerals.	*the, my, three*
Interjection	Expressive exclamation, grammatically detached.	*oh!, wow, hey*

Phrases, clauses and sentences

- **Noun phrase (NP)** — determiner + (pre-modifiers) + head noun + (post-modifier). E.g. *[the three small red boxes on the table]*.
- **Verb phrase (VP)** — main verb, optionally with auxiliaries: *[has been working]*.
- **Clause** — contains a subject and a finite verb. A main clause stands alone; a subordinate clause depends on another.
- **Sentence types:**
  - **Simple** — one main clause: *The dog barked.*
  - **Compound** — two main clauses joined by coordinator: *The dog barked and the cat ran.*
  - **Complex** — main clause + subordinate clause: *The dog barked when the doorbell rang.*
  - **Compound-complex** — multiple main + subordinate.
  - **Minor** — lacks finite verb: *Fantastic. / Why?*

Sentence functions

- **Declarative** — statement (*It\'s raining.*)
- **Interrogative** — question (*Is it raining?*)
- **Imperative** — command (*Take an umbrella.*)
- **Exclamatory** — exclamation (*What a downpour!*)

Voice: active vs passive

Active: *The council demolished the building.* Passive: *The building was demolished (by the council).* The passive lets the writer foreground the patient and optionally hide the agent — a frequent device in news reports ("Mistakes were made") and scientific writing (impersonal objectivity).

Clause-structure elements (SPOCA)

- **S** — Subject (who/what the clause is about)
- **P** — Predicator (main verb)
- **O** — Object (direct / indirect)
- **C** — Complement (follows a linking verb; describes subject or object)
- **A** — Adverbial (information about time, place, manner, reason)

Example: *[She]*$_S$ *[gave]*$_P$ *[him]*$_O$ *[a book]*$_O$ *[yesterday]*$_A$.

> **Exam Tip:** Top-band AO1 always labels grammatical features precisely *and* connects them to meaning. "The writer front-loads the temporal adverbial *Yesterday* to foreground when the event happened" is worth more than "the writer uses an adverbial".

1.1.5 Pragmatics

> **Pragmatics** is the study of meaning in context — how listeners and readers infer what a speaker or writer *intends* beyond what is literally said. It draws on shared knowledge, social relationships, politeness norms and cultural expectations.

Speech acts (Austin, Searle)

- **Locutionary act** — the literal utterance.
- **Illocutionary force** — the intended function (request, promise, apology, warning…).
- **Perlocutionary effect** — the actual effect on the hearer.

"*Could you pass the salt?*" is literally a question about ability (locutionary) but functions as a polite request (illocutionary). Its perlocutionary effect is, hopefully, the salt being passed.

Speech acts can be **direct** (form matches function: *Give me the salt.*) or **indirect** (form differs from function: *Could you pass the salt?*). Indirect speech acts are a key politeness resource.

Grice\'s Cooperative Principle

H.P. Grice proposed that conversation is cooperative, governed by four **maxims**:

Maxim	Principle	Flouting example
Quantity	Give the right amount of information — not more, not less.	A: "How was the party?" B: "There was food." — implies the party was underwhelming.
Quality	Be truthful; don\'t say what you believe to be false.	Sarcasm: "What a lovely day!" in a thunderstorm.
Relation	Be relevant.	A: "Are you coming?" B: "It\'s raining." — flouts relation to communicate refusal.
Manner	Be clear, brief and orderly; avoid ambiguity.	Deliberately vague language in politics; hedging in bad news.

When a maxim is **flouted**, the hearer infers an **implicature** — the extra meaning the speaker intends.

Politeness theory (Brown & Levinson)

Every speaker has two aspects of **face**:

- **Positive face** — the desire to be liked, approved of, included.
- **Negative face** — the desire not to be imposed on, to have autonomy.

A **face-threatening act (FTA)** (e.g. a request, criticism, refusal) risks one or both. Politeness strategies mitigate:

- **Positive politeness** — attending to positive face: compliments, inclusive "we", shared jokes.
- **Negative politeness** — attending to negative face: hedges ("sort of", "maybe"), indirect requests, apologies, modalised forms ("Could you possibly...").
- **Off-record** — hinting rather than asserting ("It\'s freezing in here" = close the window).

Deixis

Deictic expressions take their reference from the context of utterance:

- **Personal deixis** — *I, you, we*.

- **Spatial deixis** — *here, there, this, that*.
- **Temporal deixis** — *now, then, yesterday, tomorrow*.
- **Social deixis** — honorifics, address forms (*sir*, *mate*).

Deixis is economical but utterly context-bound. A transcript read out of context is often uninterpretable.

1.1.6 Discourse

> **Discourse** is language beyond the sentence. Discourse analysis considers how whole texts are organised, how they cohere, how conversations unfold, and how genre conventions shape expectations.

Cohesion and coherence

Cohesion is the set of grammatical and lexical ties that link sentences. **Coherence** is the overall sense that a text hangs together logically. A cohesive text is not automatically coherent, but coherence usually requires cohesion.

Cohesive device	Explanation	Example
Reference	Pronouns, demonstratives that point to other parts of the text.	*Harriet bought a phone. It had a large screen.* (anaphoric — points back)
Substitution	Replacing one item with another to avoid repetition.	*I need a pen. Do you have one?*
Ellipsis	Omitting words understood from context.	A: "Coming?" B: "[I am coming,] Yes."
Conjunction	Logical connectors between sentences/clauses.	*However, Furthermore, Therefore, Although*.

Lexical cohesion	Repetition, synonyms, semantic field.	*phone … screen … battery … camera* (field of mobile technology).

Turn-taking and conversation analysis

Sacks, Schegloff and Jefferson proposed that conversation proceeds through **turn-construction units**. Key concepts:

- **Adjacency pairs** — two-part exchanges: greeting/greeting, question/answer, invitation/acceptance.
- **Preferred vs dispreferred responses** — a refusal is usually delayed, mitigated, and accompanied by explanation.
- **Transition-relevance places** — points where a listener may take a turn without being considered rude.
- **Overlaps vs interruptions** — overlaps are brief and usually cooperative; interruptions violate the current speaker\'s turn.
- **Back-channelling** — minimal responses ("mm", "yeah") that show continued engagement.

Non-fluency features of spontaneous speech

- **Fillers**: *er, um, erm* — planning time.
- **False starts** — speaker begins, then restarts.
- **Repetitions** — "I was — I was going to say".
- **Self-repairs** — correcting mid-sentence.
- **Discourse markers** — *well, like, you know, so, anyway* — organise the flow of talk.
- **Uptalk** (HRT — high rising terminal) — rising intonation on declaratives, often signals tentativeness.

Halliday\'s metafunctions

M.A.K. Halliday argued that every utterance simultaneously performs three functions:

- **Ideational** — representing experience (content, processes, participants).
- **Interpersonal** — enacting relationships (stance, politeness, authority).

- **Textual** — organising the message into coherent discourse (cohesion, theme/rheme, graphology).

This is a hugely useful essay framework: for any text, ask *what does it represent? how does it position the reader? how is it organised?* Each of these maps onto several of the six levels.

> **Exam Tip:** For the exam, integrate frameworks. A single paragraph might analyse an extract\'s *lexis* (emotive monosyllabic Anglo-Saxon), *grammar* (declaratives + fronted adverbials), *pragmatics* (inclusive "we" creating positive face), and *graphology* (bold headlines) to show a coordinated persuasive register. That joined-up analysis distinguishes the top bands.

1.1.7 Applying the Frameworks — Structured Method

A reliable way to approach any Paper 1 Section A analysis is the **AFPM** planning acronym. For every text:

1. **Audience** — who is this for? How is the audience positioned?
2. **Function/Purpose** — to inform, persuade, entertain, instruct, express, build rapport?
3. **Purpose effects** — which frameworks foreground that purpose?
4. **Mode** — spoken, written, electronic, multimodal? What conventions apply?

Then write analytical paragraphs that integrate two or more frameworks per point, *always* linked to audience, purpose and effect. Use precise terminology; use quotations; use comparative structure when paired texts are given.

> **Applied Example:** Opening sentence of an analytical paragraph: "*The writer constructs a register of intimate authority by juxtaposing low-frequency Latinate lexis ('unprecedented', 'epistemology') with inclusive first-person-plural pronouns ('we', 'our'), a strategy which flatters the reader\'s intellect while positioning them alongside the speaker on matters of public importance.*" — notice the integration of lexis + grammar + pragmatics + effect on audience, all in one sentence.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and give an example of each: **phoneme, minimal pair, prosodic feature, graphology, lexis, semantic field, register, denotation, connotation, morpheme (free/bound, inflectional/derivational), noun phrase, modal auxiliary, declarative / interrogative / imperative / exclamatory, active vs passive, subordinate clause, cohesion, deixis, speech act (direct/indirect), Grice\'s maxims, implicature, face (positive/negative), politeness strategies, adjacency pair, turn-taking, back-channel, non-fluency features, Halliday\'s metafunctions, idiolect, sociolect.**

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